

THE CRANE

Grus



SIZE RANKING 45

BRIGHTEST STAR

Alnair (α) 1.7

GENITIVE Gruis

ABBREVIATION Gru

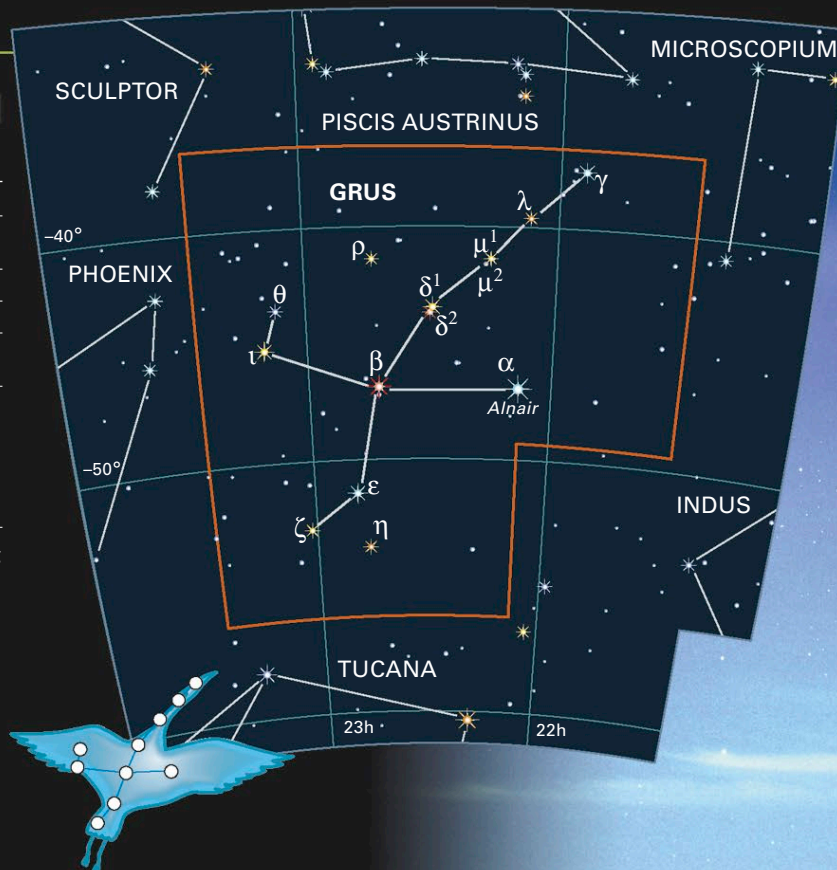
HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 PM
September–OctoberFULLY VISIBLE
33°N–90°S

Grus represents a long-necked wading bird—a crane—although it has also been depicted as a flamingo. It is a constellation of the southern sky and is situated between Piscis Austrinus and Tucana. Grus was introduced at the end of the 16th century by the Dutch navigator–astronomers Pieter Dirkszoon Keyser and Frederick de Houtman (see panel, opposite).

SPECIFIC FEATURES

Delta (δ) Gruis is a pair of 4th-magnitude giants, with one yellow component and one red one, while Mu (μ) Gruis is a pair of 5th-magnitude yellow giants. Both pairs are divisible with the naked eye. They appear double due to chance alignments and are not true binaries.

Beta (β) Gruis is a red giant whose brightness ranges from magnitude 2.0 to 2.3, with no set period.



THE CRANE

SHOWING THE WAY

Two wide doubles—Delta (δ) and Mu (μ) Gruis—appear along the extended neck of Grus, the Crane, which points to the lower right in this image.



THE PHOENIX

Phoenix



SIZE RANKING 37

BRIGHTEST STAR

Ankaa (α) 2.4

GENITIVE Phoenicis

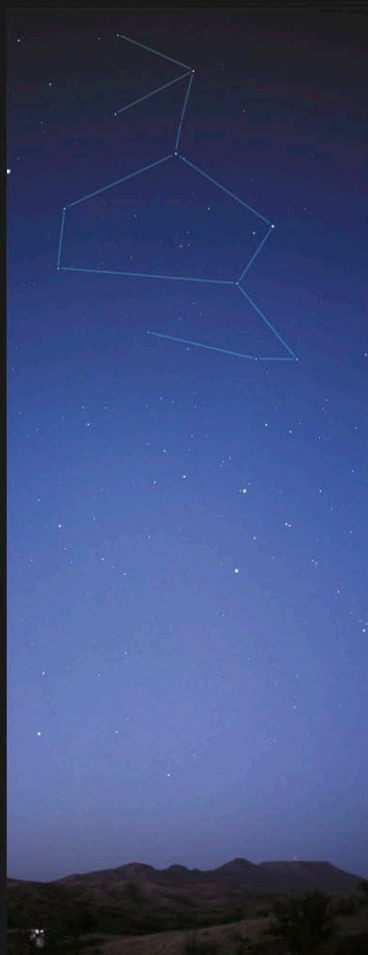
ABBREVIATION Phe

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 PM
October–NovemberFULLY VISIBLE
32°N–90°S

Phoenix lies at the southern end of Eridanus, next to that constellation's brightest star, Achernar. It is the largest of the 12 southern constellations introduced during the late 16th century by the Dutch navigator–astronomers Pieter Dirkszoon Keyser and Frederick de Houtman (see panel, opposite). It represents the mythical bird that was supposedly born from the ashes of its predecessor (see panel, right).

SPECIFIC FEATURES

Zeta (ζ) Phoenicis is a variable double consisting of a 4th-magnitude star with an 8th-magnitude companion. The brighter star is an eclipsing binary and varies between magnitudes 3.9 and 4.4 every 1.7 days.



MYTHS AND STORIES

MYTHICAL BIRD

According to legend, the phoenix was said to live for 500 years. At the end of its life span, it built a nest of cinnamon bark and incense, on which it died, some say in fire. A baby phoenix was born from its ancestor's remains. The death and rebirth of the phoenix has been seen as symbolic of the daily rising and setting of the Sun.

FUNERAL PYRE

The phoenix is consumed by fire in this 18th-century German copper engraving from *Bilderbuch für Kinder*.



PHOENIX FALLING The stars of Phoenix sink toward the western horizon in the morning sky, with Grus below it. North is to the right in this photograph.

